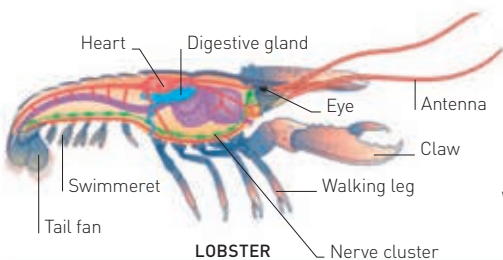


Crustaceans

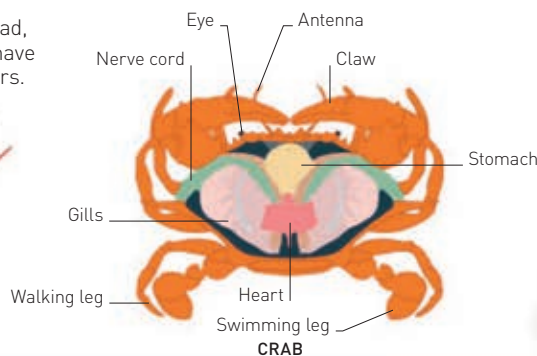
The animals called crustaceans are a varied group that includes crabs, lobsters, prawns, and shrimps. Most of them live in water. Among the few found on land are tiny woodlice. Crustaceans have an outer skeleton that does not grow when their bodies do, so they shed it regularly to allow a new, larger one to develop.

THE BODY OF A CRUSTACEAN

Lobsters and crabs have three body regions: the head, the thorax or mid-section, and the abdomen. They have five pairs of legs, which in some species form pincers.



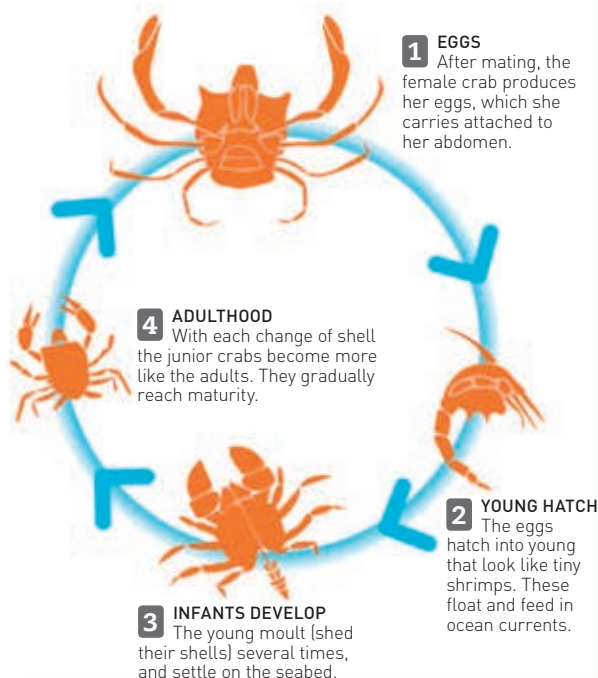
LOBSTER



CRAB

LIFECYCLE OF A CRAB

Like most crustaceans, newly hatched crabs look very different from their parents. They develop into adults through several stages. A female crab lays millions of eggs, of which only a handful survive.



SURVIVAL TACTICS

Crabs are a tasty meal for many other sea creatures. They often dodge predators by hiding under rocks or in a tangle of seaweed. If cornered a long way from shelter, a crab uses different tactics to get out of trouble.

MOCK ATTACK

The crab rears up and waves its pincers, trying to make itself look as large as possible.



CROUCH

Another trick the crab may try is to crouch down low, so that it is seen less easily by the waiting predator.



ESCAPE

With luck, the crab confuses the attacker and has time to scuttle off to safety.



CRABS

All but a few crabs live in the sea. Most of them have flat bodies and a wide shell. The soft-bellied hermit crabs protect themselves by living in the empty shells of other marine animals. Crabs move by walking sideways.



WARTY BOX CRAB



EDIBLE CRAB



SPLENDID ROUND CRAB



SPINY SPIDER CRAB



MASKED CRAB



GHOST CRAB

LOBSTERS AND OTHER FAMILIES

Like most crabs, lobsters live in the sea. These large animals have a hard upper shell and powerful tails. Smaller crustaceans include numerous shrimps, both marine and freshwater. Sea slaters and woodlice belong to a large family whose members are found on land as well as in water.



BROAD LOBSTER



VERNAL POOL TADPOLE SHRIMP



AESOP SHRIMP



COMMON EUROPEAN LOBSTER

DEADLY BUBBLE

The 5 cm (2 in) long pistol shrimp makes a big noise for its size. Meeting prey, the shrimp opens the larger of its claws and snaps it shut at lightning speed. The snap creates an air bubble, which bursts with a bang loud enough to stun the victim.



1 CLAW OPENS
The shrimp opens its hinged claw wide.



2 CLAW SHUTS
The claw snaps shut, creating a bubble.



3 PREY STUNNED
The sound of the bubble bursting stuns the prey.